many Indian diplomats remained unconvinced that Pakistan could control the Taliban remotely in the long haul.[127] These officials asserted that the Taliban have an 'ethno-nationalist' identity, disputing the consensus that the Taliban was simply an Islamist force without much regard for nationalism (like Al Qaeda).[128] Such ethnic understanding of the Taliban was a view that dominated the US foreign bureaucracy too, which was advocating a policy of 'limited engagement to try to "moderate and modernise" the Taliban', despite the repugnance of the Taliban's world-view.[129] Analysts within India's MoD had reached a similar conclusion by highlighting strains between Pakistan and the Taliban, and the limits of influence that the ISI enjoyed over the Taliban on core issues such as the Durand Line.[130]

There were divisions within the Taliban. While the moderates were inclined towards cooperating with the UN and the international community in February 1996, hardliners such as Mullah Omar gained influence due to Pakistan's support.[131] The flexibility of this assessment and the conciliators' thriving existence is reflected in debates during the temporary fall of Mazar-e-Sharif on 25 May 1997. As the Taliban moved west and north from Kandahar, most factional leaders including Hekmatyar and Herat's Ismail Khan fled Afghanistan. Mazar-e-Sharif's fall initiated Dostum's exile as well. The only faction actively resisting the Taliban was the *Jamiat*, confined to the Panjshir valley north of Kabul. India, like many other countries, momentarily faced a fait accompli, that is either it engaged with the Taliban or remained out of Afghanistan for the foreseeable future. The situation became acute when the US received a Taliban delegation in Washington in February 1997 while Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) recognised it as Afghanistan's legitimate government.[132]

On 26 May 1997 the MEA came out with a cautious statement saying that the 'new situation is entirely within the domestic sphere of Afghanistan,' and Afghans have a right to decide their future 'free from outside influence and interference'.[133] On 28 May 1997, three days after Mazar's fall, Indian media reported: 'India seeks to open channel with Taliban.'[134] According to the report, a fast-emerging 'dominant' view in the MEA was that India will 'have to deal with the reality in Afghanistan' for its 'long term national interest'.[135] Officials had privately started admitting that India's Afghanistan policy over the last year had 'met with a